

Quantifying Hidden Exploitation: Dual-Method Prevalence Estimates of Modern Slavery Risk Among UK Domestic Workers

Purpose

The purpose of this article is to demonstrate a quantitative approach to the construction of a risk index of labour exploitation and alternative estimators of the prevalence of exploitation.

Design/ Methodology/ Approach

Using data from a survey of domestic workers based in the United Kingdom (UK), we use statistical techniques, including Respondent Driven Sampling (RDS) methods RDS-I and RDS-SS and Network Scale Up (NSUM) methods, to produce an index of labour exploitation risk and estimators of the prevalence of labour exploitation.

Findings

The labour exploitation risk index shows a reverse correlation between the increasing seriousness of exploitation and the number of exploitation cases reported. The various prevalence estimators examined show significant differences in population level exploitation.

Research implications/ limitations

Further research into the application of different quantitative statistical estimators of the prevalence of labour exploitation is urgently required.

Practical implications

Robust estimators are necessary if policy makers are to make informed choices about the appropriate allocation of scarce resources to help to eradicate severe forms of labour exploitation and labour abuse.

Social implications

Even by more conservative estimates, thousands of domestic workers in the UK are subject to labour exploitation. Urgent policy attention is needed if structural vulnerabilities are to be removed.

Originality

We believe this paper is the first to compare the use of RDS and NSUM methods in the quantitative estimation of the prevalence of labour exploitation and to construct a quantitative, composite index of labour exploitation risk.

Introduction

Labour exploitation has been defined as ‘work situations that deviate significantly from standard working conditions as defined by legislation or other binding legal regulations, concerning in particular remuneration, working hours, leave entitlements, health and safety standards and decent treatment’ (European Union for Fundamental Rights, 2015, p. 10). In the operations and supply chain management literature, interest in businesses’ respect for these kinds of employee labour rights began with studies focused upon labour rights transgressions related to risk reduction and risk communication and how to improve employees’ health and safety (Chinander, 2001; Wolf, 2001). More recently, serious labour rights abuses have come to the fore with studies examining the challenges of severe labour exploitation under the umbrella term ‘modern slavery’ (Benstead et al., 2018; Gold et al., 2015; New, 2015; Stevenson & Cole, 2018). While this literature offers important insights into severe forms of labour exploitation, particularly in global supply chains, this and the wider social sustainability literature has been criticised for its de-humanised approach to the understanding of workers and their working conditions (Soundararajan et al., 2021). While at least one current project seeks to examine the phenomenon of worker voice in factory settings (Leverhulme Trust, 2022), there appears to be little attention paid to severe forms of labour exploitation from the workers’ perspective in the private sphere. Nowhere are the realities of individual workers’ experiences of employer exploitation brought into sharper relief than in the setting of domestic work in private households.

The authors of the Global Slavery Index estimate that there are seventy-six million people employed in domestic work worldwide (International Labour Organization et al., 2022). According to (Bonnet et al., 2022), eighty percent of this domestic work is unregulated and informal. Labour exploitation has been identified as an extensive global problem within the sector, with domestic work identified as one of five private sector groupings which contribute the most to forced labour. Defined in the ILO Forced Labour Convention, 1930 No.29, forced or compulsory labour is ‘all work or service which is exacted from a person under the threat of a penalty and for which the person has not offered himself or herself voluntarily’ (I.L.O., 2024). Seventy-six percent of domestic workers are women, and these workers represent four percent of the total female workforce (International Labour Organization et al., 2022). Indeed, women in forced labour are much more likely to be in domestic work than in any other occupation (International Labour Organization et al., 2022). The ILO suggest that female domestic workers may be coerced through non-payment of wages; abuse of vulnerability; subjected to physical and sexual violence or experience threats against their family members. Such severe forms of labour exploitation may be present alongside other, perhaps less severe but equally illegal, practices which constitute various forms of labour abuse. The criminalisation of both labour exploitation and abuse in a domestic setting has developed in recent times, with legislation enacted in the United Kingdom (UK), Europe, Australia and Norway to criminalise such severe exploitation under the term ‘modern slavery.’ However, even where modern slavery laws are in place, reliance on traditional, inspection-led, approaches to detection designed primarily to ensure labour rights compliance within communal workplaces such as factories mean that the number of reported cases of labour exploitation in private dwellings may well severely underestimate actual exploitation levels. Though an exploration

of labour exploitation within private residences, our research seeks to redress the paucity of rigorous quantitative research in the modern slavery field. Specifically, this article aims to contribute to a more nuanced understanding of how quantitative methodologies may be deployed to improve understanding of the realities of workers' conditions by demonstrating the use of a statistically robust estimation of the nature and proportion of labour exploitation and abuse among domestic workers in the UK. This setting was chosen due to long-standing national legislation criminalising modern slavery introduced to the UK in 2015. Despite, or perhaps because of this legislation, in recent years the number of potential victims entering the UK's National Referral Mechanism (NRM), a scheme which provides government support for those suspected to be modern slavery survivors, has continued to increase. Nineteen thousand, one hundred and twenty-five potential victims were recorded in 2024: the highest annual figure since the NRM began (Home Office, 2025). In 2024, for the first time the number of cases of potential modern slavery among females handled by the charity Unseen, who run the UK's modern slavery helpline, were more prevalent than those among men (Carter, 2025). Despite these worrying headline statistics, and the persistence of specific concerns about high levels of exploitation among domestic workers in the grey literature (Kalayaan, 2008; Latin American Women's Rights Service, 2023; Mantouvalou, 2016), to our knowledge no-one has yet estimated the nature and extent of labour exploitation and abuse that may exist among domestic workers in the UK.

In contrast to overseas factory workers in globally dispersed, product, supply chains, many service workers engaged in domestic work have migrated to work in the UK. These transnational workers enter on restricted visas where their employment—and their right to remain in the country—is tied to their continuing employment. It is now ten years since the UK's Modern Slavery Act was enacted. During its passage through parliament, those advocating for the rights of domestic workers were successful in expanding the final category boundaries of the legislation to include, in Section 53, the specific definition of (overseas) domestic workers as modern slavery victims (Caruana et al., 2025). These transnational migrants are at particular risk of exploitation due to regulatory visa restrictions and intersecting structural issues related to their gender, the relative isolation of domestic work and a lack of supportive social networks. This can mean that they fall out of legal migratory status. Due to the social stigma attached to such illegal working, transnational workers remaining in the UK without the right to work may be considered a hidden, hard-to-reach, population. Extracting a sample of domestic workers which includes this group raises difficulties when trying to employ the normal statistical sampling methods considered necessary for robust prevalence estimation. Perhaps due to these sampling difficulties, we know relatively little about the nature of labour exploitation among this particularly at-risk group of workers. Fortunately, there has been significant interest in the development of alternative methods for prevalence estimation which include such hard-to-reach groups, with many scholars advocating and developing the use of respondent-driven sampling (RDS) techniques to support statistically robust estimators.

In this paper, we make two specific contributions to the operations and supply chain management literature. First, we demonstrate the use of RDS coupled with Network Scale-up Methods (NSUM) to reach and sample respondents' views of their working conditions among these, predominantly female, transnational migrant domestic workers. We use the data we

obtain from these respondents to show how quantitative survey data can be used to estimate the proportion of workers experiencing labour exploitation. Second, we begin to capture the nature and extent of modern slavery as voiced by domestic workers, thus, we believe, expanding the nascent literature on worker voice which has, in the main, focused primarily on factory workers (Stephens et al., 2024). These contributions not only extend our understanding of the risks of labour exploitation and abuse among service workers engaged in domestic settings but also show how it is possible to shed light on the severity of the individuals' experience of exploitation through the construction of a novel risk index. The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. First we discuss our study in more detail, highlighting what is already known about the current population of domestic workers in the UK and the conditions in which they work. Next, we describe our research methods. We review the development of the respondent-driven sampling (RDS) techniques we used and explain why this sampling method is suitable for our study. We then describe our survey methods, including how we designed our survey instrument, contacted our sample seeds and analysed our data. We then present and discuss our findings, detailing the proportional estimate that we calculated and the risk index we constructed. In our discussion, we expand upon the implications of our findings for government policy, enforcement practices and further research, including how these methods may be used in future studies of labour exploitation in other sectoral and geographic contexts. The limitations of our study are outlined, before, finally, we conclude our article.

Conceptualising Labour Exploitation and the Degree of Risk

Modern slavery has been criticised by some for its overly extensive scope: encapsulating a broad range of divergent sub-categories of exploitation (Gutierrez-Huerter O et al., 2023; O'Connell Davidson, 2015). For this reason, we used the International Labour Organization's (I.L.O., 2011) 'Indicators of Forced Labour' to identify the potential for severe labour exploitation and as a basis for the quantification of our labour exploitation and abuse risk index. The ILO identify eleven indicators designed to help understand how forced labour arises and how it affects victims. These indicators include: abuse of vulnerability; deception; restriction of movement; isolation; physical and sexual violence; intimidation and threats; retention of identity documents; withholding of wages; debt bondage; abusive working and living conditions and excessive overtime. According to the ILO, the presence of a single indicator in any given situation may in some cases imply the existence of forced labour. However, it also suggests that in other cases it may be necessary to look for several indications which, taken together, may point to a case of forced labour. We seek to refine this statement through the construction of a composite index by which means a degree of risk related to the likelihood of a domestic worker experiencing this most severe form of exploitation may be distinguished from the likely occurrence of less severe, though similarly illegal, forms of labour abuse.

Evaluating the Degree of Risk

The study of risk management has a long tradition in operations and supply chain management. Initially, the risks under consideration were primarily related to ensuring continuity of the supply of goods and services – see for example, Jüttner et al. (2003). Beginning with Anderson (2006) and Anderson and Anderson (2009), however, a literature stream of sustainability-related supply chain risk management developed related specifically to the risks associated with the environment and social justice. A normative consensus related to the main stages of supply chain risk management has developed in the literature, with a five-stage sequential model typically presented. There have also been empirical studies of risk management within various industrial supply chains in the United States and India (Dellana et al., 2021; Tarei et al., 2018), including the quantification of a risk index for the petroleum supply chain (Tarei et al., 2018). Yet, while these authors recognize the need for responsible management and its effect on societal values, in line with other literature in the field they view risk from the perspective of the corporate supply chain rather than examining the risk of harm to the worker.

In our study, we conceptualise the risk of labour exploitation from the workers’ perspective. We conceive severe forms of labour exploitation such as forced labour as one end of a spectrum ranging from illegal employment practices that constitute labour abuse, such as wage payments below legal minimum wage levels and health and safety violations, through to the likelihood of criminal exploitation recognized in the UK as modern slavery. Our assessment of this personal risk permits a degree of risk to be assigned to various clusters of forced labour indicators with the more indicators present, the stronger the likelihood that the working conditions may be considered exploitative. Along with this novel conceptualization of labour exploitation (LE) as a continuous *risk index* (or risk score – see Appendix A for details of its construction) we also employ a series of dichotomous indicators.

The survey instrument included modules on demographic and employment characteristics, social network size and composition, and indicators of labour exploitation. The exploitation indicators were based on the International Labour Organization’s framework of forced labour, adapted for the UK domestic work context. These indicators allowed us to operationalise exploitation in two ways. First, we constructed binary indicators classifying respondents as exploited or not exploited, based on threshold criteria. Second, we developed a continuous risk index, designed to capture gradations of vulnerability across the full sample.

Our approach, therefore, includes, but goes beyond, assessing the likelihood of forced labour by simply quantifying the proportion of survivors entering the UK’s National Referral Mechanism (NRM): a government system for survivor support set up to identify whether there are positive grounds for the identification of Modern Slavery. In our method, an NRM referral is used as the strongest indicator of modern slavery risk, with lesser risks assessed according to the degree to which cumulative indicators of forced labour are reported.

Case Setting: Labour Exploitation Risk Among Transnational Migrant Domestic Workers In The UK

Domestic work forms part of a broader industrial category of Personal and Household Service work (PHS). Work in this category includes those employed in ‘social work activities without accommodation’ and ‘activities of households as employers of domestic personnel’ (European Commission, 2012). In 2017, an estimated 980,000 people were engaged in PHS work in the UK (Manoudi et al., 2018). Manoudi et al. (2018) highlight that the PHS sector is dominated by women and migrants, with many undeclared foreign workers. Detailed statistics related to the country of origin of domestic workers migrating to work in PHS in the UK are difficult to isolate before 2019. Since that time, annual migration has fluctuated – falling sharply in 2021 due in part to the COVID-19 pandemic, before later rising again above pre-pandemic levels. In the year to December 2022, the UK Home Office reported that it had issued 18,533 Overseas Domestic Worker visas (Home Office, 2023). These domestic workers came from various countries in South America and Asia, including many from the Philippines.

CAROLINE: DO WE NEED THE FOLLOWING PARAGRAPH? In 2023, Strauss and Cocco (2023) reported a big shift in the source countries of migrants arriving in the UK on the Overseas Domestic Worker and other types of worker visas. Transnational domestic workers from the Philippines and India accounted for the single largest number of applications granted (10,186 and 3,858 visas respectively), followed by smaller, but still significant, numbers of workers arriving from Bangladesh (465), Nigeria (446), Sri Lanka (444), Egypt (422), and Ethiopia (285). In the same period, smaller numbers of visa applications to work as a domestic worker in the UK were also accepted from workers from other source countries including, but not limited to, the Sudan, Nepal, Ghana, Kenya, Lebanon, Eritrea, Iran, Turkey, Yemen, Malaysia, Thailand, and Morocco. This post-Brexit increase in the diversity of source countries from which transnational workers are drawn makes a more detailed analysis of the risk of labour exploitation in the sector both timely and more urgent.

There is a long history of reports of exploitation in the domestic work sector in the UK. In 2008, the civil society organisation Kalayaan, which was formed to campaign for the formal recognition of migrant domestic workers’ rights in the UK, reported on the impact of proposed changes to the UK immigration system on migrant domestic workers (Kalayaan, 2008). Their report highlights government recognition of documented and unacceptable levels of abuse and exploitation among domestic workers in the UK as early as 1996. At this stage, new policies, including the development of a specialised visa allowing domestic workers to change employer during their stay were introduced. However, in 2012, these visa conditions were modified, tying domestic workers to a single employer and restricting the length of time that they are permitted to remain in the country to a period of six months (Gower, 2016). Overseas domestic worker visa holders are now, again, permitted to change employers, but not to apply to renew their six-month long visa unless they receive a positive ‘Conclusive Grounds’ decision related to exploitation considered to be modern slavery through the UK’s NRM (Romero & Fisher, 2025).

These reports highlight the underlying reasons for migrant domestic workers’ vulnerability, including workers’ relative desperation for work; their lack of social ties; unfamiliarity with

English language and culture; long working hours; lack of knowledge of their legal rights; a lack of oversight of the private home as a workplace; their work forming part of the informal economy; their reliance on their employer for permission to work in the UK; and their lack of recourse to public funds. As a result, migrant domestic workers are vulnerable to abuse ranging from minor breaches of employment and health and safety law, to physical and sexual violence, slavery, forced labour and trafficking.

That these conditions may persist is evidenced by a report from another civil society organisation, the Latin American Women’s Rights Service, which describes the results from twelve in-depth interviews with Latin American domestic workers in the UK. This report depicts high levels of isolation, exploitation and abuse including a failure by employers to provide written contracts or payslips; breaches of verbal agreements; a requirement to perform different tasks from those indicated during recruitment; increasing working hours with little or no time off; excessive work days; a lack of paid holiday; many domestic workers not registered with a GP; sexual harassment in the workplace; verbal or physical abuse; employer surveillance; a lack of opportunity to change working conditions; isolation and fear of seeking help; and high reported levels of trafficking for labour exploitation (Latin American Women’s Rights Service, 2023).

Against this backdrop, we used respondent driven sampling (RDS) as a sampling technique to recruit and survey domestic workers in the UK about the working conditions they were experiencing to estimate the nature and scale of abuse and exploitation based upon reports of their conditions by domestic workers themselves.

Methods and Estimation Strategy

Study Design and Sampling

Respondent-Driven Sampling (RDS) is a network-based sampling method designed to study hidden or hard-to-reach populations (Gile et al., 2018; Heckathorn, 1997, 2011). It combines chain-referral sampling with a statistical framework to produce population estimates that adjust for network structure and differential recruitment probabilities. The method begins with a set of initial participants (“seeds”), who recruit peers from their social networks. Recruits, in turn, recruit others, creating waves of participation. Each participant reports their network degree (the number of eligible contacts they know), which is used to adjust for selection bias—especially the oversampling of high-degree individuals.

RDS has been widely used to sample hidden populations in public health and social science research (McCreesh et al., 2012; Schwitters et al., 2012), and network-based referrals have been described as the only viable method to reach many types of labour trafficking victims (Zhang, 2012). Recent applications include studies of exploitation among low-wage workers in American cities (Bernhardt et al., 2009), labour trafficking in migrant communities (Vincent & Thompson, 2017), child labour in India (Zhang et al., 2019), and commercial sexual exploitation in Nepal (Jordan et al., 2020).

Our approach can best be described as Web-based RDS (Wejnert & Heckathorn, 2008). We designed a web survey using the JISC online survey interface, suitable for respondents to complete via mobile phone. The main survey was conducted over five months between February and July 2023.

Seed Selection and Recruitment

We selected our first wave of participants nonrandomly by convenience sampling. Mobile phone numbers were used both to identify seed participants and to act as a unique identifier for those whom they referred. To avoid sample homophily, original sample members were selected from three distinct domestic worker communities facilitated by civil society organisations. One was an exclusively online community of transnational domestic workers working in the UK, the second represented UK domestic workers of Filipino origin, and the third drew its membership from the Latin American community of domestic workers, also in the UK. Representatives from these organisations, along with other academics with expertise in exploitation within domestic work, contributed to survey question design and facilitated piloting of an initial version of the survey, which was translated and made available in four languages: English, Spanish, Tagalog, and Portuguese.

Incentive Design and Participation Verification

A double incentive scheme rewarded respondents both for completing the questionnaire and for each referral who went on to engage with the survey. The challenge of incentive design is to set the incentive at a level that adequately rewards respondents' time and participation, but that also avoids the risk of fraudulent participation due to too high a monetary gain (Jordan et al., 2020). A sum of £10 was provided for survey completion with a further £5 for each successful nomination. While respondents were asked to nominate up to 10 domestic workers within their existing social network, it was the up to five of these from whom participation was requested in subsequent waves. This approach is akin to the use of vouchers in face-to-face studies as advocated by Thompson (2020).

The ethical and practical issues related to the design and effective use of incentives for RDS among vulnerable populations has been much discussed in the literature; see, for example, Wang et al. (2005); Abdul-Quader et al. (2006); Singer and Bossarte (2006); DeJong et al. (2009); Semaan et al. (2009); Brunovskis and Surtees (2010); Semaan (2010); Platt et al. (2015), including the specificities of incentive use within web-based surveys (Cobanoglu & Cobanoglu, 2003). Following the principles of lottery use established by Brown et al. (2006) and Laguilles et al. (2011), we also designed our survey to encourage the maximum extent of participation by entering all respondents completing the questionnaire into a free prize draw for £150. Research suggests that a high lottery provides the most cost-effective incentive for obtaining complete responses (Gajic et al., 2012). While using incentives to encourage participation would seem to be desirable, it is worth noting the potential downside of respondents fabricating responses to increase their remuneration (Robinson, 2014). To minimise this risk, mobile phone numbers for each respondent and those whom they referred

were collated, and each of these numbers was called by one of the authors of the paper to ascertain the veracity of the respondent as a migrant domestic worker.

Survey Instrument and Indicators

The survey instrument was designed to capture both egocentric (ego-based) and altercentric (alter-based) network information, enabling the application of both RDS and NSUM estimation methods. Composite measures to quantify the extent to which respondents were at risk of labour exploitation, including severe forms of exploitation such as forced labour, were constructed from existing exploitation typologies, notably the ILO’s Indicators of Forced Labour (I.L.O., [2011](#)).

The survey consisted of 11 composite indicators and included questions related to domestic workers’ level of job satisfaction, employment conditions, and demographic data such as nationality, age, and gender. Based on these indicators, we operationalize exploitation in two ways: (1) five dichotomous (binary) indicators classifying respondents as exploited or not exploited based on threshold criteria, and (2) one continuous risk index designed to capture gradations of vulnerability across the full sample.

Ego-based questions capture respondents’ own experiences of exploitation (used for RDS estimation), while alter-based questions ask respondents to report on the exploitation experiences of domestic workers they know (used for NSUM estimation). See Appendix A for details of these survey questions and the construction of comparable ego- and alter-based indicators.

Sample Characteristics

In total, we received completed online surveys from 97 respondents. Twelve participants reported knowing zero domestic workers in the UK—that is, having a null social network—and were excluded from RDS analysis because network degree information is required for RDS weighting procedures. This resulted in an analytical sample of 85 respondents for RDS-based estimation.

Of the 97 initial respondents, 90 identified themselves as transnational migrants. Forty-five percent regarded themselves as self-employed, 39% identified themselves as employees, and 16% categorised their employment status as that of a worker. The largest single nationality group, comprising 64 respondents (66% of the total), reported a Filipina background. Other nationalities represented included Dominican, Brazilian, Spanish, Colombian, Bolivian, Venezuelan, Cuban, and Panamanian. Female domestic workers made up 97% of the sample, with 3% of the sample comprised of male domestic workers. The age structure of the domestic workers was skewed towards those over 45 years old, with such workers representing over half of the sample (see Table 1).

Figure 1 presents the recruitment network structure for the 85 respondents included in RDS analysis.

Table 1: RDS Sample Characteristics by Nationality Cluster and Recruitment Wave. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Nationality	N	%	Seeds	Recruits	Mean Degree	Median Degree
Filipino	62	72.9	31	31	11.3	5
Latinx	17	20.0	13	4	6.9	5
Other	6	7.1	2	4	7.5	4

Note: Degree refers to reported network size (Q13: number of domestic workers known).

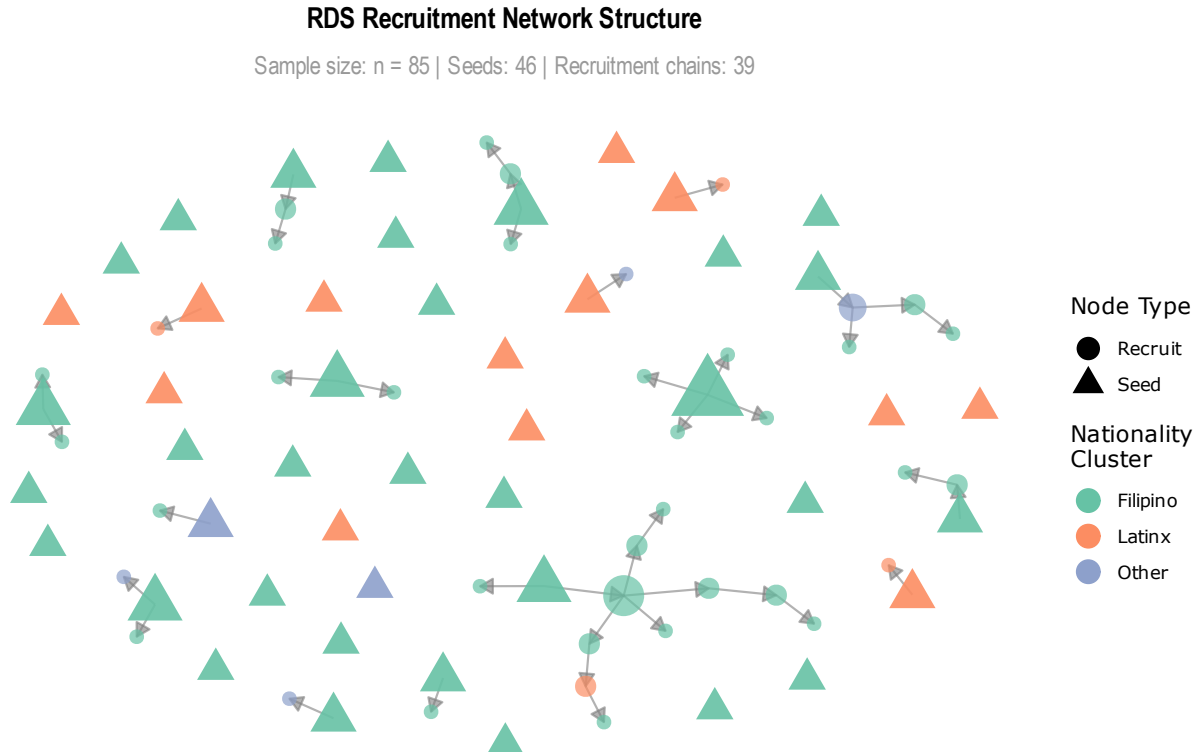


Figure 1: RDS Network Structure: Recruitment chains showing seed nodes (triangles) and recruit nodes (circles). Node colors represent nationality clusters, with node size proportional to out-degree (number of recruits). Lines show recruiter-recruit relationships. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Ethical Approval and Use of AI

The data collection that underpins the analysis presented in this paper was given favourable ethical approval by the lead author's School Research Ethics Committee in January 2023. All participants were informed about the aims of the study, provided informed consent, and were assured that participation was voluntary and confidential.

Large Language Models (LLMs) were used for brainstorming the organisation of the paper and editing of text. Code co-pilot (Claude Code) was used to test and debug R scripts

employed in the statistical analysis. No generative models were used to generate or simulate data.

Estimation Framework

We analysed the survey sample using multiple estimation models to assess robustness and conduct sensitivity analyses (see Appendix B). The dual structure of our survey instrument—capturing both ego-based and alter-based network information—enables two fundamentally different estimation strategies: Respondent-Driven Sampling (RDS) estimators and Network Scale-Up Methods (NSUM).

To the best of the authors’ knowledge, the combined use of both methods in the same study is rare in peer-reviewed academic research, though it has appeared in government-funded reports and technical documents from NGOs and research organizations (Hickman et al., 2025; IST Research & University of California, Los Angeles, 2020). This paper contributes to the emerging methodological literature on combining RDS and NSUM in survey research for hidden populations. We also developed a novel three-step bootstrap procedure to address uncertainty in NSUM estimates.

RDS Estimation

We implemented three RDS estimators, each with distinct assumptions: RDS-I (Salganik & Heckathorn, 2004), the Volz–Heckathorn (VH) estimator (Volz & Heckathorn, 2008), and Gile’s Successive Sampling (RDS-SS) estimator (Gile, 2011). Given our small sample (85 respondents) and non-negligible sampling fraction, RDS-SS serves as our primary estimator for binary outcomes because it accounts for finite population effects. RDS-I, which performs poorly in small samples and is highly sensitive to seed dependence, is retained as a historical benchmark.

For continuous outcomes such as the exploitation risk index, we employ Model-Assisted (MA-RDS) estimators (Gile & Handcock, 2015). MA-RDS is design-based yet leverages a working Exponential Random Graph Model (ERGM) with degree and homophily terms to approximate inclusion probabilities conditional on observed seeds. This approach directly addresses seed bias and homophily that conventional RDS estimators cannot correct, accommodates finite-population effects through successive-sampling logic, and supports valid estimation of both binary and continuous outcomes. By conditioning on actual seed composition and subgroup structure, the method reduces bias, improves efficiency, and provides design-compatible bootstrap uncertainty (Gile, 2011).

NSUM Estimation

We employ the Modified Basic Scale-Up (MBSU) model (Feehan & Salganik, 2016), which improves upon the original Basic Scale-Up Method by accounting for key sources of bias.

The traditional method assumes that respondents can accurately report how many people they know in the hidden population and that all members are equally likely to be known. These assumptions often fail due to stigma, recall issues, or social barriers.

The MBSU addresses this through two primary adjustments. First, the degree ratio adjustment () accounts for differences in network size between the hidden population and frame population. Second, the visibility/true positive rate adjustment () corrects for underreporting of connections to hidden population members due to stigma or lack of awareness. We apply these adjustments with sensitivity analysis across multiple parameter values: $\{0.8, 0.9, 1.0\}$ and $\{0.7, 0.85, 1.0\}$, where $=1.0$ and $=1.0$ represent the unadjusted baseline scenario.

Comparative Rationale: Ego-Based vs. Alter-Based Inference

RDS and NSUM both exploit social network structures but use fundamentally different information for inference. RDS uses ego-based information: respondents report their own characteristics and network degree, which are combined with recruitment wave to adjust for unequal inclusion probabilities. The underlying logic is that individuals with larger networks are more likely to be recruited, creating bias toward highly connected respondents. RDS estimators explicitly correct for this by weighting observations according to network degree and recruitment path.

NSUM uses alter-based information – respondents serve as informants about the wider hidden population, reporting how many people they know with specific traits. These reports are scaled up using assumptions about network size and visibility to infer prevalence in the broader population. NSUM does not depend on recruitment chains but instead on the accuracy of respondents’ knowledge about others in their social circles.

Applying both methods to the same dataset allows for triangulation across two fundamentally different inferential logics—one anchored in “who recruited whom” (RDS), the other in “how many alters fit this category” (NSUM).

Bootstrap and Sensitivity Procedures

To appropriately characterise uncertainty in NSUM estimates, we developed a novel three-step bootstrap procedure. This approach resamples respondents, their reported alters, and the exploitation classifications simultaneously, thereby capturing uncertainty at each stage of the inference process. This procedure provides more realistic confidence intervals than those generated by conventional variance estimators, particularly for small samples such as ours. Details of the bootstrap implementation and diagnostic checks are provided in Appendix C.

For RDS estimators, we employ neighborhood bootstrap methods that preserve the network structure while resampling (Yauck et al., 2022). Sensitivity analyses examine robustness to

population size assumptions (50K, 100K, 980K, 1.74M) and NSUM adjustment factor values. Full results are reported in Appendix B.

Results

Descriptive Overview

Sample characteristics are presented in Table 1 and Figure 1 (Section 3.3). In total, 97 respondents completed the survey, of whom 85 had non-zero network degree and were included in RDS analysis. The analytical sample comprised 90 transnational migrants (93%), with the largest nationality cluster being Filipino (66%). Female domestic workers constituted 97% of the sample, with over half aged 45 or older. Self-employment status was reported by 45% of respondents.

Model-Assisted Estimates of the Continuous Risk Index

One of the central contributions of this study is the introduction of a continuous risk index to measure degrees of exposure to labour exploitation. The index was constructed from multiple indicators aligned with the ILO’s forced labour framework, weighted inductively and refined through expert consultation. Rather than treating exploitation as a dichotomy, the risk index conceptualises all domestic workers as facing some degree of potential exploitation, albeit with significant variation in intensity.

Because continuous traits cannot be estimated directly with conventional RDS estimators or NSUM, we employed model-assisted inference methods (Gile & Handcock, 2015). These methods adjust for the non-random structure of RDS recruitment while permitting reliable estimation of means and distributions of continuous outcomes.

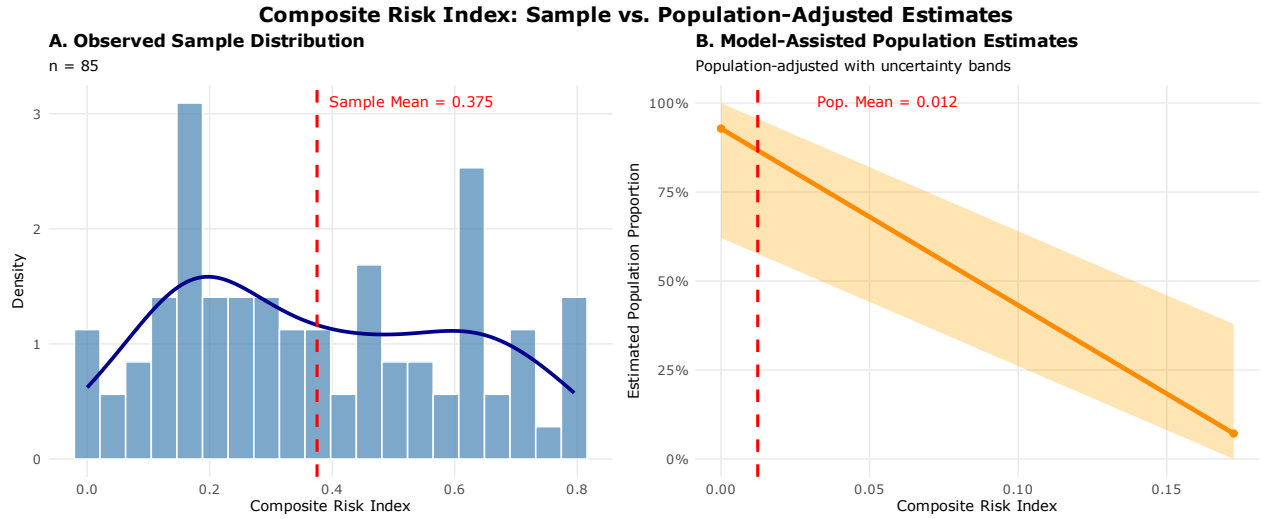


Figure 2: Model-Assisted Estimates of Composite Risk Index: Distribution comparison between observed sample data and population-adjusted estimates. The left panel shows the empirical distribution of risk scores in the RDS sample, while the right panel presents the model-assisted population proportion estimates for specific risk categories with uncertainty bounds (the light band shows confidence intervals around the proportion estimates). Source: Authors' Own Work.

Figure 2 presents the comparison between the observed sample distribution and the model-assisted population estimates, demonstrating how the bias correction affects our understanding of exploitation risk in the broader domestic worker population. The population-weighted average risk is 0.0124. This represents the Model-Assisted estimate of mean exploitation risk in the population, adjusted for RDS sampling bias. It is a design-based estimate that corrects for the non-random recruitment process in RDS. The population-adjusted distribution shows less concentration in the lower risk values compared to the raw sample. The MA estimate suggests that 7.2% of DWs in the UK have moderate risk (0.1725). This pattern reinforces the conceptual claim that exploitation is best understood as a continuum rather than a simple binary condition.

Binary Exploitation Indicators: Comparative RDS–NSUM Estimates

To complement the continuous measure, we operationalised exploitation as binary outcomes. Respondents were classified as exploited if they met threshold indicators consistent with ILO definitions. We present prevalence estimates from three approaches: (1) Model-Assisted (MA-RDS) Bayesian estimates that adjust for RDS sampling bias, (2) frequentist RDS estimators (RDS-I and RDS-SS) for comparison, and (3) Network Scale-Up Method (NSUM) estimates with multiple adjustment factor scenarios.

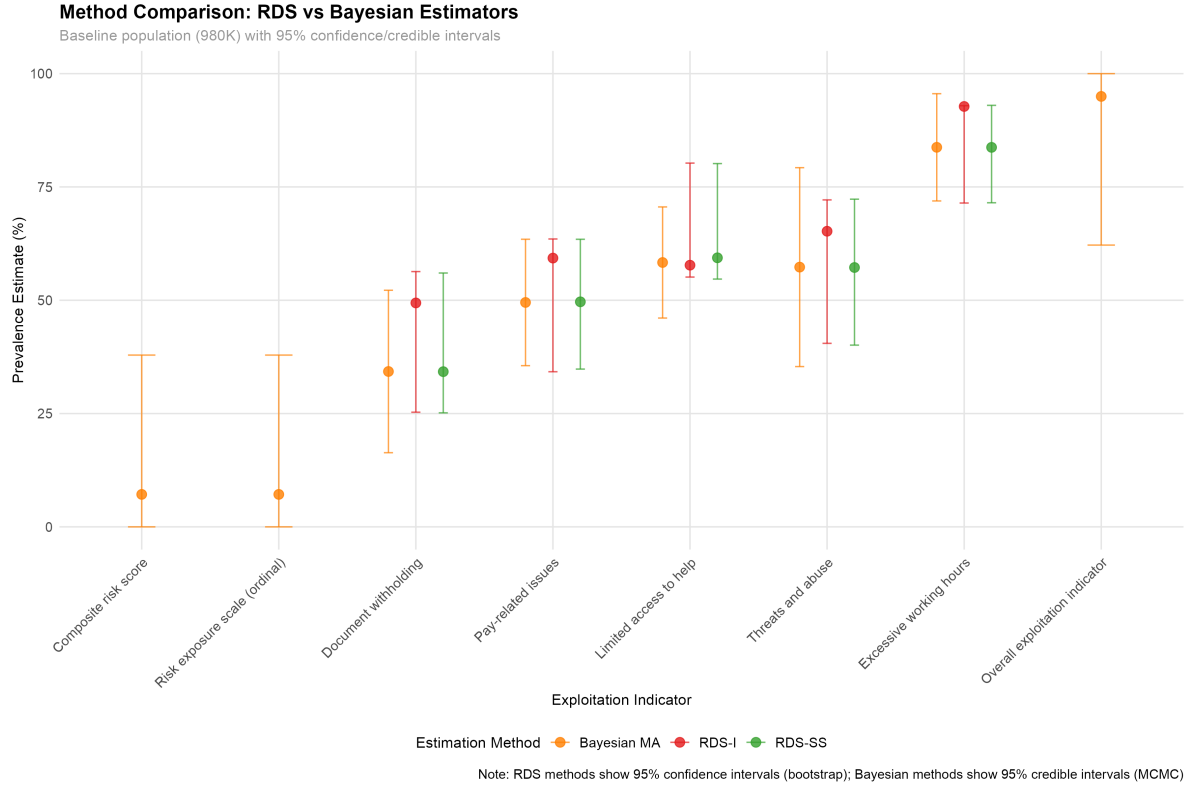


Figure 3: Comparative Method Overview: Point estimates and uncertainty intervals for prevalence of exploitation indicators across different estimation methods. RDS methods show 95% confidence intervals (bootstrap); Bayesian methods show 95% credible intervals (MCMC); NSUM shows estimates under different adjustment scenarios. Baseline population assumption: 980,000 domestic workers. Source: Authors' own work.

Figure 3 provides a comprehensive comparison of prevalence estimates across all three approaches. While absolute values differ—reflecting the fundamental differences between ego-based (RDS) and alter-based (NSUM) inference—the overall pattern is remarkably stable. Excessive hours consistently shows the highest prevalence across all methods, followed by threats/abuse and pay-related issues. Model-Assisted estimates generally fall between RDS frequentist estimates and NSUM baseline estimates, though NSUM estimates are highly sensitive to adjustment factor assumptions.

Table 2: Model-Assisted Bayesian Estimates of Binary Exploitation Indicators: Population prevalence estimates adjusted for RDS sampling bias using Bayesian inference. Values represent estimated proportions with 95% credible intervals. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Exploitation Indicator	Population Prevalence (95% CrI)
Any Exploitation	95.0% (62.2-100.0%)
Excessive Hours	83.7% (71.9-95.6%)
Limited Access to Help	58.3% (46.1-70.6%)
Threats/Abuse	57.3% (35.4-79.3%)
Pay-Related Issues	49.5% (35.6-63.5%)
Document Withholding	34.3% (16.4-52.2%)

Note: Estimates adjusted for RDS sampling bias using Bayesian Model Assisted Inference (Gile & Handcock, 2015). N=980,000; sample seed selection. Credible intervals from posterior distribution.

Model-Assisted Bayesian Estimates

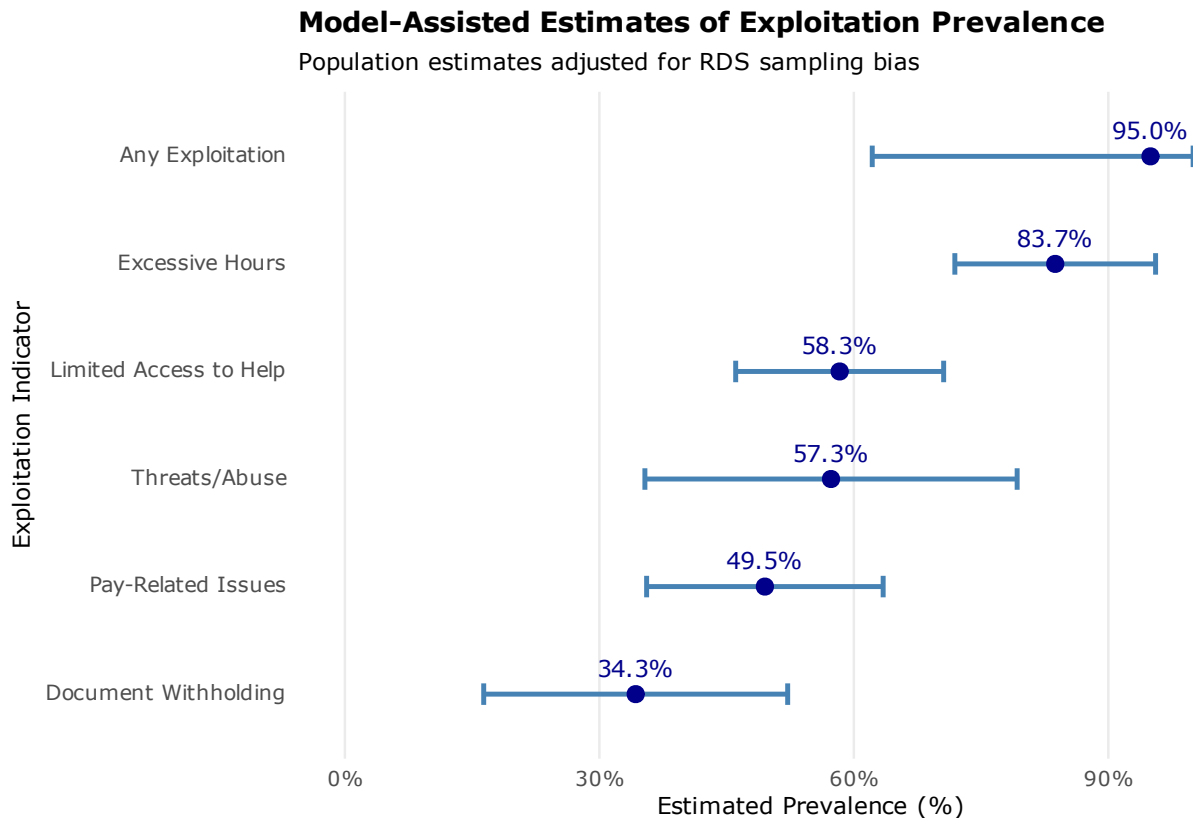


Figure 4: Forest Plot of Model-Assisted Binary Exploitation Estimates: Population prevalence estimates with 95% credible intervals for each exploitation indicator, ordered by prevalence magnitude. Error bars represent posterior uncertainty from Bayesian MA-RDS (N=980,000, sample seed selection). Source: Authors' Own Work.

Table 3: Frequentist RDS Estimates of Binary Exploitation Indicators: Comparison of RDS-I and RDS-SS estimators with neighborhood bootstrap confidence intervals (N=980,000). Source: Authors' Own Work.

Exploitation Indicator	RDS-I	RDS-SS
Document withholding	49.4% (25.3–56.3)	34.2% (25.2–56.0)
Excessive working hours	92.8% (71.4–92.9)	83.7% (71.5–93.0)
Limited access to help	57.7% (55.1–80.3)	59.4% (54.7–80.2)
Pay-related issues	59.3% (34.2–63.5)	49.7% (34.8–63.4)
Threats and abuse	65.2% (40.5–72.1)	57.2% (40.1–72.3)

Note: RDS-I: Salganik-Heckathorn estimator. RDS-SS: Gile's Successive Sampling estimator. Confidence intervals from neighborhood bootstrap (n=1000). Population: 980,000 domestic workers.

Frequentist RDS Estimates

Table 3 compares RDS-I and RDS-SS estimators for binary exploitation indicators. As expected, RDS-SS produces slightly more conservative estimates than RDS-I due to its finite population correction. Both estimators show similar relative patterns across indicators, with Figure 5 visualizing the comparison.

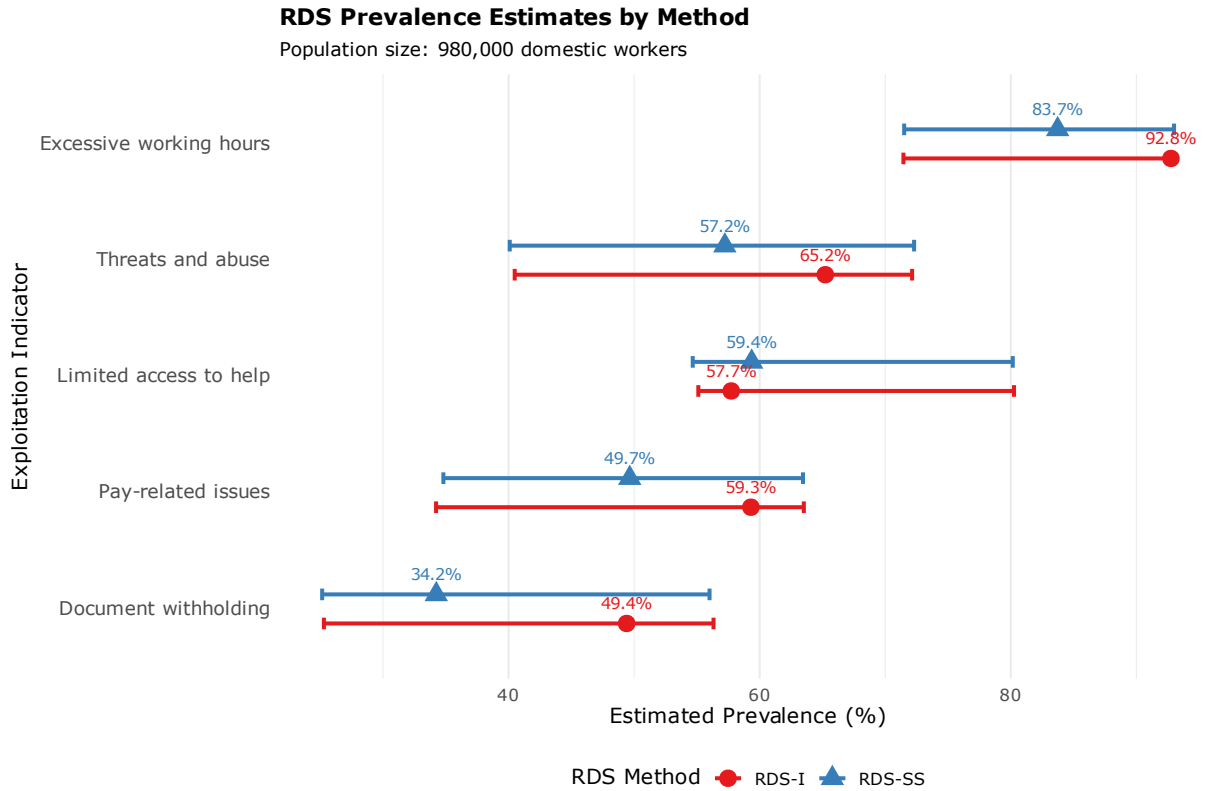


Figure 5: Forest Plot of RDS Estimates: Comparison of RDS-I and RDS-SS prevalence estimates for binary exploitation indicators (N=980,000). Error bars represent 95% bootstrap confidence intervals. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Network Scale-Up Method (NSUM) Estimates

Using the Modified Basic Scale-Up (MBSU) estimator (Feehan & Salganik, 2016) with Sequential Sampling weights and a UK domestic worker population of 980,000, Table 4 presents prevalence estimates under three adjustment scenarios: (1) unadjusted baseline ($\alpha=1.0$, $\beta=1.0$), (2) moderate adjustments ($\alpha=0.9$, $\beta=0.85$), and (3) conservative adjustments ($\alpha=0.8$, $\beta=0.7$).

NSUM estimates show substantial sensitivity to adjustment factor assumptions. Unadjusted estimates range from 0.83% (document withholding) to 2.28% (excessive hours). Conservative adjustments accounting for network degree differences and visibility barriers produce estimates approximately 1.8 times higher—ranging from 1.48% to 4.08%—while moderate adjustments yield intermediate values approximately 1.3 times the baseline. Wide confidence intervals reflect substantial uncertainty inherent in network-based estimation methods, particularly for small hidden populations.

Robustness Checks

A series of robustness checks were performed to assess the stability of the findings. In Appendix B, a comprehensive analysis comparing all prevalence estimates across indicators, methods, and parameter values is presented. There, remarkable consistency is demonstrated across different analytical approaches. The pattern of estimates is remarkably stable across methods, with excessive hours consistently showing the highest prevalence, followed by threats/abuse and pay-related issues, while document withholding shows more moderate prevalence levels. This cross-method validation strengthens confidence in our findings and demonstrates the robustness of the dual estimation approach. Full technical details are reported in Appendices B and C.

Discussion

Summary of Findings

This study estimated prevalence of labour exploitation among UK domestic workers using both Respondent-Driven Sampling (RDS) and Network Scale-Up Method (NSUM). We introduced a continuous risk index alongside binary exploitation indicators based on ILO forced labour criteria. Model-Assisted RDS estimates suggest prevalence rates ranging from 34% to 84% for various exploitation indicators among respondents. In contrast, NSUM estimates—highly sensitive to adjustment factors—range from 0.83% to 4.08% depending on assumptions about network degree differences (α) and visibility/reporting accuracy (β). The pattern across methods is remarkably consistent: excessive working hours shows the

Table 4: NSUM Prevalence Estimates for Labor Exploitation Indicators: Estimates using Modified Basic Scale-Up (MBSU) method with Sequential Sampling weights and population size of 980,000 domestic workers. Adjustment factors: δ (, degree ratio) controls for network size differences; τ (, visibility/true positive rate) controls for reporting accuracy and visibility barriers. Bootstrap confidence intervals based on neighborhood resampling (B=1000). Source: Authors' Own Work.

Adjustment Method	Outcome	Point Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	Prevalence (%)
No Adjustment ($\delta=1.0$, $\tau=1.0$)					
MBSU (Conservative)	Access to Help	27,164.671	8,933.933	65,323.13	2.77% (0.91% - 6.67%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Document Withholding	14,500.488	3,968.605	41,872.57	1.48% (0.40% - 4.27%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Excessive Hours	39,955.494	24,677.066	73,760.07	4.08% (2.52% - 7.53%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Pay Issues	38,499.114	25,438.688	76,102.17	3.93% (2.60% - 7.77%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Threats/Abuse	35,966.277	24,834.407	78,445.77	3.67% (2.53% - 8.00%)
Conservative ($\delta=0.8$, $\tau=0.7$)					
MBSU (Moderate)	Access to Help	19,885.249	6,539.872	47,818.24	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Document Withholding	10,614.737	2,905.123	30,651.82	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Excessive Hours	29,248.467	18,064.258	53,994.30	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Pay Issues	28,182.358	18,621.784	55,708.78	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Threats/Abuse	26,328.255	18,179.435	57,424.35	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)
Moderate ($\delta=0.9$, $\tau=0.85$)					
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Access to Help	15,212.216	5,003.002	36,580.95	1.55% (0.51% - 3.73%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Document Withholding	8,120.274	2,222.419	23,448.64	0.83% (0.23% - 2.39%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Excessive Hours	22,375.077	13,819.157	41,305.64	2.28% (1.41% - 4.21%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Pay Issues	21,559.504	14,245.665	42,617.22	2.20% (1.45% - 4.35%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Threats/Abuse	20,141.115	13,907.268	43,929.63	2.06% (1.42% - 4.48%)

Note: MBSU = Modified Basic Scale-Up method; δ = degree ratio ($d_{H,F}/d_{F,F}$); τ = visibility/true positive rate ($\bar{v}_{H,F}/\bar{d}_{H,F}$); Bootstrap: neighborhood resampling (n=1000); Population: 980,000 UK domestic workers.

highest prevalence, followed by threats/abuse and pay-related issues, while document withholding shows more moderate levels. Robustness checks across different population size assumptions and estimation approaches confirm the stability of these relative patterns.

Methodological Reflections and Contributions

This study makes several methodological contributions to the estimation of prevalence in hidden and hard-to-reach populations:

Dual conceptualisation of exploitation: We introduce two distinct approaches to operationalising exploitation. First, we treat exploitation as a binary outcome (exploited versus not exploited), enabling direct comparison of prevalence estimates across RDS and NSUM methods. Second, we construct a continuous risk index, acknowledging that all domestic workers may be exposed to some degree of exploitation risk. To our knowledge, this is the first application of model-assisted RDS estimators to quantify a continuous measure of exploitation risk.

Combining RDS and NSUM on the same survey instrument: By designing a survey that captures both ego and alter information, we are able to apply RDS and NSUM to the same sample. This dual approach has rarely been implemented in studies of labour exploitation. It provides an opportunity to cross-validate results and assess the robustness of prevalence estimates.

Novel bootstrap procedure for NSUM: Recognising the non-random nature of an RDS sample, we developed a three-step bootstrap procedure tailored for NSUM estimation. This resamples respondents, recalculates weights, and re-estimates NSUM prevalence at each iteration. The procedure captures multiple layers of uncertainty and produces more reliable confidence intervals than conventional methods, particularly in small samples.

Application to domestic workers in the UK: Finally, by applying these methods to a population that is both highly stigmatised and under-researched, we demonstrate the feasibility of using advanced network-based estimation techniques in contexts where traditional sampling is impossible. This methodological innovation has potential applications in studies of other hidden labour markets and vulnerable populations.

Interpreting RDS–NSUM Divergence: The Role of Visibility

Substantial discrepancies between hidden population prevalence estimates derived from Respondent-Driven Sampling (RDS) and the Network Scale-Up Method (NSUM) are widely observed in empirical research and simulation studies. In the present case, for example, egocentric RDS-based estimates suggest that 34% to 84% of respondents personally experienced indicators of exploitation. In contrast, the corresponding NSUM estimates suggest that only 2.9% to 5.1% of the general domestic worker population experiences these same harms. This stark divergence—often approaching an order of magnitude—warrants a careful methodological explanation.

Among the various sources of error affecting NSUM, the most important and widely documented is visibility bias, also referred to in some literature as transmission bias. Visibility refers to the extent to which members of a hidden population are known to belong to that population by members of the general population. In the context of NSUM, visibility determines whether a respondent can accurately report having connections to members of the hidden group. If visibility is low—because of stigma, secrecy, or lack of awareness—respondents will systematically underreport these ties. This causes a downward bias in the numerator of the NSUM estimator, thereby underestimating the size of the hidden population.

This issue has been recognized since the earliest implementations of NSUM. Bernard et al. describe it as a failure of the transmission condition—the assumption that a respondent will be aware of, and willing to disclose, the group membership of their contacts (Bernard et al., 2010). More recently, Maltiel et al. have addressed visibility bias using model-based (Bayesian) approaches, which estimate and correct for differential visibility between groups (Maltiel et al., 2015).

In contrast, RDS estimators such as the Volz–Heckathorn and especially the Successive Sampling (SS) estimator rely on direct self-reporting of hidden group membership. That is, RDS respondents are asked whether they themselves belong to the group or exhibit a trait of interest. This egocentric measurement bypasses the visibility problem entirely. While RDS relies on its own set of assumptions—such as the random recruitment assumption, accurate self-reported degree, and a sufficiently connected social network—visibility is not among its main sources of bias.

Thus, while both NSUM and RDS are used to estimate the size or prevalence of hidden populations, they are subject to fundamentally different sources of error. In NSUM, low visibility leads to systematic underreporting, which can result in severe underestimation unless appropriately adjusted. Adjustments such as those proposed by Feehan and Salganik—including multiplicative correction factors for degree ratio (δ , network size differences), visibility/true positive rate (τ , transmission and reporting accuracy), and frame ratio (ϕ_F , ϕ_F)—can mitigate these biases, but require additional data or assumptions (Feehan & Salganik, 2016).

In our setting, where RDS estimates suggest that over 50% of respondents have experienced some form of labour exploitation, but NSUM estimates suggest only 3–5% of the domestic worker population does so, visibility bias is almost certainly the dominant factor explaining the discrepancy. This is especially true in contexts involving exploitation, abuse, or trafficking—where group membership is often concealed both by victims and by observers. Respondents in the frame population may simply be unaware that their contacts are experiencing exploitation, leading to substantial underreporting.

Hence, visibility bias is a major and well-understood limitation of NSUM, and likely the principal reason why our NSUM estimates are substantially lower than those derived from RDS. The use of RDS-based estimators, particularly those that adjust for sample design such as Gile’s SS estimator, provides direct measurement of traits among the hidden population and avoids the visibility problem. Therefore, RDS estimates are often more accurate in

estimating prevalence within the hidden population, whereas NSUM estimates are typically biased downward unless adjusted for visibility and related biases.

Policy and Theoretical Implications

The UK Government has proved reluctant to respond to calls to remove the restrictive, tied, visa conditions currently in force for those migrant workers working in the UK on the Overseas Domestic Workers visa (Gower, 2016). Maintaining these restrictive conditions prevents the ratification in the UK of C189, the International Convention for Domestic Workers (I.L.O., 2011). If the estimates resulting from our study are correct, these visa conditions place migrant domestic workers at significant risk of serious forms of labour exploitation including, in its most severe form, exploitation that exhibits the characteristics of forced labour—legally considered a form of modern slavery.

To reduce the vulnerability of transnational domestic workers to this—and other—forms of labour exploitation, we urge policy-makers to reconsider these discriminatory visa conditions and offer the same freedoms to domestic workers that are enjoyed by other groups of workers under UK law.

In addition, given the vulnerabilities experienced by workers due to the private nature of the workplace, we would urge the UK government to consider the regulation of domestic worker employers.

Finally, given the stigma and very real danger of deportation of those migrant domestic workers who may have fallen out of legal migration status, our evidence suggests that there is an urgent need for the UK Government to enforce a firewall between immigration control and labour exploitation if the true scale of abuse is to be made visible and the perpetrators brought to justice.

The UK Visa and Immigration service already offers rights-based training to migrant domestic workers via UK embassies in certain source countries. To reduce migrant domestic workers vulnerabilities, we advocate the expansion of this training both to include explicit training related to employment and labour rights within the UK and to the rapidly expanding range of new source countries from where migrant domestic workers are now drawn.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

As with any empirical research, our study is subject to limitations. In terms of nationality, our sample is not representative of the demographics of those domestic workers employed on Overseas Domestic Worker Visas in 2022 the UK. Due to the increasing number of workers on Overseas Domestic Work visas from the Indian sub-continent, attempts were made also to seed respondents from this community. This proved difficult, with anecdotal information suggesting that domestic workers from this community rarely had access to a personal mobile phone. It is not therefore possible to infer the nature and extent of labour exploitation within this sub-section of the domestic worker population.

As the network structure of our sample demonstrates, even with a well-designed incentive scheme it proved difficult to recruit respondents from these communities of domestic workers in subsequent sampling waves in the time available. Most of our respondents are therefore original sample members drawn from the three domestic worker communities used to seed the survey.

We believe that web-RDS combined with statistical estimators such as NSUM offers an important method for the capture and comparison of relative proportions of labour exploitation and abuse in sectors within and beyond the UK. Network scale up methods, and potential enhancements such as Generalised network scale up estimators offer to enhance understanding, not least within operations and supply chain management research, of the extent of labour exploitation in different sectors and across industries. The differences in NSUM and RDS estimates warrants further investigation and suggests research into *combining* multiple estimates may be a fruitful direction in human rights research and especially prevalence of modern slavery research.

Conclusion

This article examines original quantitative data collected from domestic workers based in the UK to measure and assess the nature and prevalence of labour exploitation among this vulnerable population. Our contribution lies in the presentation of two different statistical estimators based upon RDS and NSUM techniques and the construction of both binary and composite risk indices from indicators recognised by the International Labour Organization. In so doing, we shed new light on the nature and extent of labour exploitation risk among these vulnerable workers, who enter the UK on restricted visas in the hope of decent work. The results of our analysis raise important questions for both theory and practice about the range and accuracy of the estimates that it is possible to generate using these statistical techniques. Meaningful and trustworthy estimates of labour exploitation among such vulnerable groups are required if policymakers are to use prevalence measures to make sensitive decisions about policy adjustments and the allocation of scarce resources to ensure entrants to the UK labour market experience decent working conditions. We believe our study opens the way for further research on the efficacious use of statistical estimators to measure the size of hidden populations of exploited workers and the identification of appropriate means to quantify the extent of labour exploitation reported.

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Appendix A

The Survey Questions

(From codebook)

Compare corresponding survey questions between RDS and NSUM methods:

- Q70/Q71 (document withholding)
- Q39+Q42/Q43 (pay issues)
- Q45+Q47+Q48/Q49 (abuse/threats)
- Q61+Q62/Q64 (excessive hours)
- Q78/Q79 (access to help)

Risk Index Implementation

- Clean coding for 13 risk categories with proper weightings
- NRM referral (0.35)
- Forced labor indicators (0.55 total)
- Below minimum wage (0.10)

Data Processing

The process of coding variables to make them comparable across the Respondent-Driven Sampling (RDS) and Network Scale-Up Method (NSUM) estimations is a multi-step procedure that moves from conceptual mapping to specific data transformations. The core challenge is bridging the “egocentric” questions (about the respondent’s own experiences, used for RDS) with the network-based questions (about how many others the respondent knows with certain experiences, used for NSUM). The fundamental challenge is to create a fair comparison between the “egocentric” RDS questions (about personal experience) and the broader “how many do you know” NSUM questions. This was accomplished by first identifying thematic links between questions and then implementing a specific coding scheme to transform them into a consistent format.

Thematic Groups for Comparison:

- Document Withholding (Most Confident): Comparing personal experience (Q70) with knowing others who lack access to their documents (Q71).
- Pay/Debt Issues (High Confidence): Linking personal experience with debt (Q39) and withheld pay (Q42) to knowing others with such problems (Q43).
- Threats/Abuse (High Confidence): Aggregating personal experiences of being forced, threatened, intimidated, or verbally abused (Q45, Q47, Q48) and comparing them to knowing others who experienced threats or force (Q49).

- **Excessive Hours (Lower Confidence):** Combining questions about inadequate weekly rest (Q61) and excessive overtime (Q62) to compare with knowing others who face similar labor rights issues (Q64). The confidence is lower because the NSUM question (Q64) also asks about annual leave, which is not covered in the corresponding RDS questions.
- **Access to Help (Least Confident):** Matching whether the respondent personally knows where to go for help (Q78) with knowing others who do not (Q79). Coding and Transformation Process The conceptual mapping was then put into practice through a detailed coding process, which is explicitly documented in the project’s R script.

The primary goal was to convert all variables into a binary (0/1) format, representing “No” or “Yes” to experiencing or knowing someone who experienced the issue.

Key Coding Steps:

1. **Handling Ambiguous Answers:** For most RDS questions, responses like “I don’t know” or “Prefer not to say” were recoded as NA (missing) to exclude them from the binary analysis.
2. **Converting Categorical RDS Variables to Binary:** Questions with multiple response options (e.g., “Always,” “Often,” “Sometimes,” “Never”) were recoded into a 0/1 format. For instance, for Q70 (document withholding), the answers “Always,” “Often,” and “Sometimes” were all coded as 1 (indicating the presence of the issue), while “Never” was coded as 0.
3. **Aggregating Multiple RDS Questions:** For themes covered by multiple egocentric questions (like “Threats/Abuse”), each individual question was first recoded into a binary 0/1 variable. These binary variables were then combined using a logical OR (|). This means if a respondent answered “Yes” to any of the grouped questions (e.g., experiencing threats OR intimidation OR verbal abuse), the final composite RDS variable would be coded as 1. This aggregation was necessary to match the broader scope of the single corresponding NSUM question.
4. **Converting NSUM Count Variables to Binary:** The NSUM questions, which asked for a numerical count (e.g., “how many do you know?”), were also converted to binary. If a respondent knew one or more people (> 0), their answer was coded as 1; if they knew zero, it remained 0.

Indicators

Creating comparable variables to bridge the Respondent-Driven Sampling (RDS) and Network Scale-Up Method (NSUM) estimations is a key methodological challenge the research team is actively working to solve. The core issue is that the two methods rely on differently framed questions:

- RDS estimation uses “egocentric” questions, which focus on the respondent’s personal experiences (e.g., “Have you been forced to work?”).

- NSUM estimation uses questions about the respondent’s knowledge of others in their network (e.g., “How many domestic workers do you know who have experienced...”). The survey questions designed for these two purposes do not always match up directly, making a fair comparison between the estimates difficult.

The goal is to aggregate some of the specific “egocentric” questions to make them comparable to the broader “how many do you know” NSUM questions. To accomplish this, several sets of “linking” questions have been identified with varying degrees of confidence in their comparability:

- Document Withholding (High Confidence):
 - RDS Question: Q70 asks if the employer has withheld the respondent’s travel and identity documents.
 - NSUM Question: Q71 asks how many other domestic workers the respondent knows who do not have access to their own documents.
- Debt and Pay Issues (High Confidence):
 - RDS Questions: This involves combining Q39 (having to pay off debt to someone who helped find work) and Q42 (has your pay ever been withheld?).
 - NSUM Question: Q43 asks how many others the respondent knows who have experienced problems with debt or pay.
- Abuse and Threats (Medium Confidence):
 - RDS Questions: This requires grouping Q45 (forced, deceived, or threatened into poor working conditions), Q47 (employer intimidation or threats), and Q48 (verbal abuse).
 - NSUM Question: Q49 asks how many others the respondent knows who have experienced the use of threat or force.
- Excessive Hours (Lower Confidence):
 - RDS Questions: Q61 (weekly rest does not last 24 hours) and Q62 (working excessive overtime) are combined.
 - NSUM Question: Q64 asks about knowing others who work excessive overtime, lack breaks, or lack annual leave. The comparison here is considered “flakier” because the RDS questions do not ask about annual leave, creating a partial mismatch.
- Access to Help (Lower Confidence):
 - RDS Question: Q78 asks if the respondent knows who might help them (coded for “No” answers).
 - NSUM Question: Q79 asks how many other domestic workers the respondent knows who do NOT know where to go for help.

Table 5: Comprehensive RDS Estimates: Prevalence estimates for all indicators across population sizes and RDS methods (RDS-I, RDS-SS) with neighborhood bootstrap confidence intervals.

Indicator	RDS-I Estimator				RDS-SS Estimator			
	50K	100K	980K	1.74M	50K	100K	980K	1.74M
Document withholding	49.4% (25.5–56.2)	49.4% (25.2–55.9)	49.4% (25.3–56.3)	49.4% (25.4–56.1)	34.2% (25.6–56.2)	34.2% (25.1–56.5)	34.2% (25.2–56.0)	34.2% (25.3–56.5)
Excessive working hours	92.8% (71.8–92.8)	92.8% (71.8–92.5)	92.8% (71.4–92.9)	92.8% (71.7–92.8)	83.7% (71.5–93.0)	83.7% (71.5–93.0)	83.7% (71.5–93.0)	83.7% (71.6–92.8)
Limited access to help	57.7% (54.7–80.0)	57.7% (54.8–79.8)	57.7% (55.1–80.3)	57.7% (54.9–80.0)	59.4% (54.9–80.1)	59.4% (55.1–80.2)	59.4% (54.7–80.2)	59.4% (54.8–80.1)
Pay-related issues	59.3% (34.5–63.5)	59.3% (34.8–63.0)	59.3% (34.2–63.5)	59.3% (34.2–63.6)	49.7% (34.0–63.8)	49.7% (34.2–64.1)	49.7% (34.8–63.4)	49.7% (34.6–63.5)
Threats and abuse	65.2% (40.3–71.7)	65.2% (40.2–72.0)	65.2% (40.5–72.1)	65.2% (40.6–72.1)	57.2% (40.9–72.5)	57.2% (40.9–72.0)	57.2% (40.1–72.3)	57.2% (40.6–72.6)

Note: RDS-I: Salganik-Heckathorn estimator; RDS-SS: Gile's Successive Sampling estimator. Population sizes represent assumed UK domestic worker totals: 50K, 100K, 980K, and 1.74M. Estimates shown as prevalence (95% CI) from neighborhood bootstrap with 1,000 resamples.

Appendix B

This analysis estimates the prevalence of modern slavery among domestic workers in the UK using multiple RDS methodologies. We examine two primary indicators across various population size assumptions and estimation techniques.

RDS Estimation Results

This section presents comprehensive RDS estimates across all population size scenarios and estimation methods.

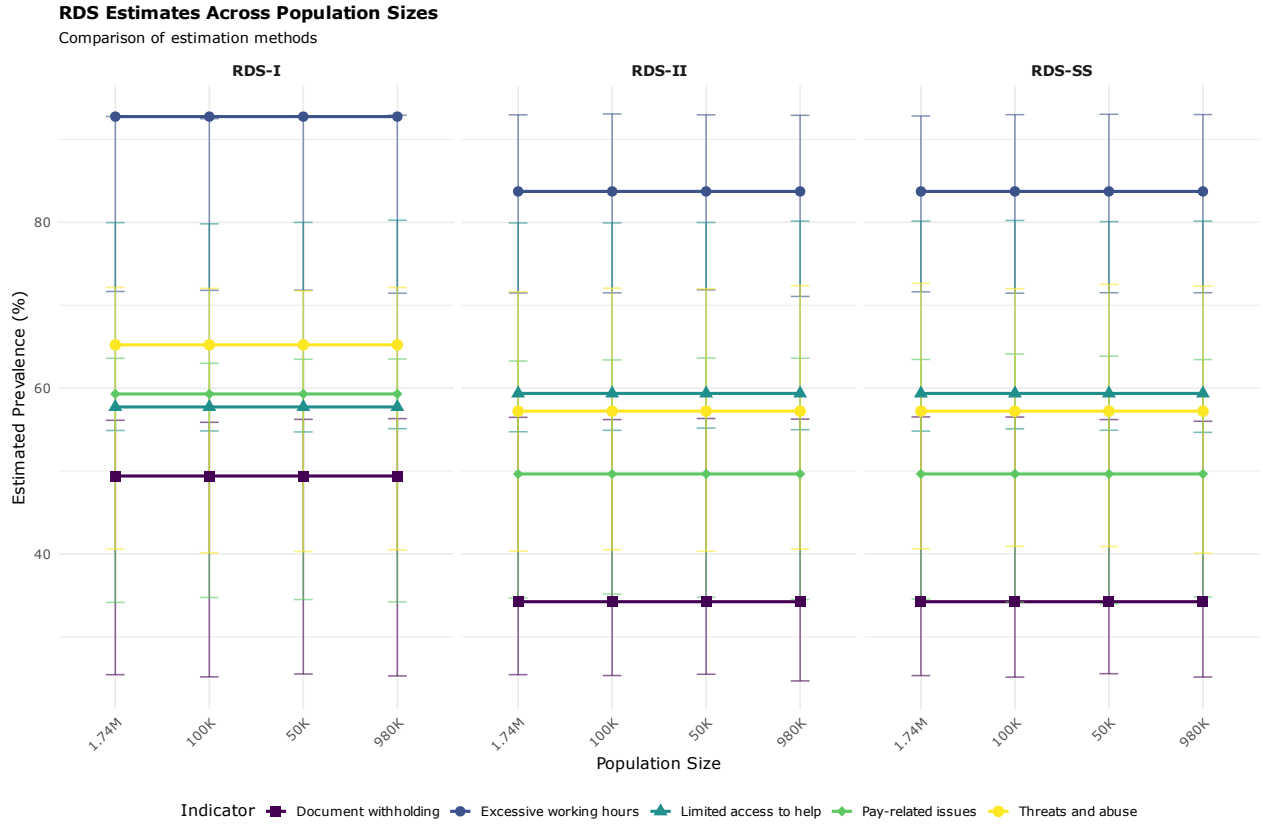


Figure 6: RDS Sensitivity to Population Size: Comparison of RDS estimates across all population size scenarios. Each panel shows one RDS method with point estimates and 95% bootstrap confidence intervals varying by population size.

Model-Assisted Estimates by Population Size

Model-Assisted Sensitivity Analysis

This section presents comprehensive sensitivity analysis for Model-Assisted inference estimates across all exploitation indicators, examining robustness to population size assumptions and seed selection methods. Figure 7 and Figure 8 show MA estimates are robust to these parameter choices.

Table 6: Model-Assisted Estimates by Population Size and Seed Selection. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Seed Selection	Population Size	Prevalence Estimates (95% CrI)			
		Document Withholding	Pay Issues	Excessive Hours	Threats/Abuse
sample	50,000	34.1% (16.1%, 52.1%)	49.3% (35.2%, 63.4%)	84.0% (72.3%, 95.8%)	57.1% (34.6%, 79.6%)
sample	980,000	34.3% (16.4%, 52.2%)	49.5% (35.6%, 63.5%)	83.7% (71.9%, 95.6%)	57.3% (35.4%, 79.3%)
sample	1,740,000	34.3% (16.0%, 52.7%)	49.1% (34.9%, 63.3%)	83.8% (72.1%, 95.6%)	57.0% (34.7%, 79.3%)
random	50,000	34.1% (16.1%, 52.1%)	49.3% (35.2%, 63.4%)	84.0% (72.3%, 95.8%)	57.1% (34.6%, 79.6%)
random	980,000	34.3% (16.4%, 52.2%)	49.5% (35.6%, 63.5%)	83.7% (71.9%, 95.6%)	57.3% (35.4%, 79.3%)
random	1,740,000	34.3% (16.0%, 52.7%)	49.1% (34.9%, 63.3%)	83.8% (72.1%, 95.6%)	57.0% (34.7%, 79.3%)
degree	50,000	34.1% (16.1%, 52.1%)	49.3% (35.2%, 63.4%)	84.0% (72.3%, 95.8%)	57.1% (34.6%, 79.6%)
degree	980,000	34.3% (16.4%, 52.2%)	49.5% (35.6%, 63.5%)	83.7% (71.9%, 95.6%)	57.3% (35.4%, 79.3%)
degree	1,740,000	34.3% (16.0%, 52.7%)	49.1% (34.9%, 63.3%)	83.8% (72.1%, 95.6%)	57.0% (34.7%, 79.3%)

Note: Model-Assisted estimates from Gile & Handcock (2015) Bayesian inference. CrI = Credible Interval from posterior distribution.

Table 7: Model-Assisted Sensitivity Analysis: Point estimates and 95% credible intervals across all parameter combinations. Estimates from Gile & Handcock (2015) Bayesian Model-Assisted inference.

label	Degree: 50K	Random: 50K	Sample: 50K	Degree: 980K	Random: 980K	Sample: 980K	Degree: 1.74M	Random: 1.74M	Sample: 1.74M
Document Withholding	34.1% (16.1-52.1%)	34.1% (16.1-52.1%)	34.1% (16.1-52.1%)	34.3% (16.4-52.2%)	34.3% (16.4-52.2%)	34.3% (16.4-52.2%)	34.3% (16.0-52.7%)	34.3% (16.0-52.7%)	34.3% (16.0-52.7%)
Pay Related Issues	49.3% (35.2-63.4%)	49.3% (35.2-63.4%)	49.3% (35.2-63.4%)	49.5% (35.6-63.5%)	49.5% (35.6-63.5%)	49.5% (35.6-63.5%)	49.1% (34.9-63.3%)	49.1% (34.9-63.3%)	49.1% (34.9-63.3%)
Threats/Abuse	57.1% (34.6-79.6%)	57.1% (34.6-79.6%)	57.1% (34.6-79.6%)	57.3% (35.4-79.3%)	57.3% (35.4-79.3%)	57.3% (35.4-79.3%)	57.0% (34.7-79.3%)	57.0% (34.7-79.3%)	57.0% (34.7-79.3%)
Excessive Hours	84.0% (72.3-95.8%)	84.0% (72.3-95.8%)	84.0% (72.3-95.8%)	83.7% (71.9-95.6%)	83.7% (71.9-95.6%)	83.7% (71.9-95.6%)	83.8% (72.1-95.6%)	83.8% (72.1-95.6%)	83.8% (72.1-95.6%)
Limited Access to Help	58.2% (46.0-70.4%)	58.2% (46.0-70.4%)	58.2% (46.0-70.4%)	58.3% (46.1-70.6%)	58.3% (46.1-70.6%)	58.3% (46.1-70.6%)	58.4% (46.2-70.7%)	58.4% (46.2-70.7%)	58.4% (46.2-70.7%)
Any Exploitation	94.9% (61.5-100.0%)	94.9% (61.5-100.0%)	94.9% (61.5-100.0%)	95.0% (62.2-100.0%)	95.0% (62.2-100.0%)	95.0% (62.2-100.0%)	94.8% (59.2-100.0%)	94.8% (59.2-100.0%)	94.8% (59.2-100.0%)

Note: Estimates from Gile & Handcock (2015) Bayesian Model-Assisted inference. Population sizes: 50K, 100K, 980K, 1.74M domestic workers. Seed methods: Degree (by network degree), Random, Sample (from data). CrI = Bayesian credible interval.

Sensitivity of MA Estimates to Population Size and Seed Selection

Gile & Hancock (2015) Bayesian Model-Assisted Inference

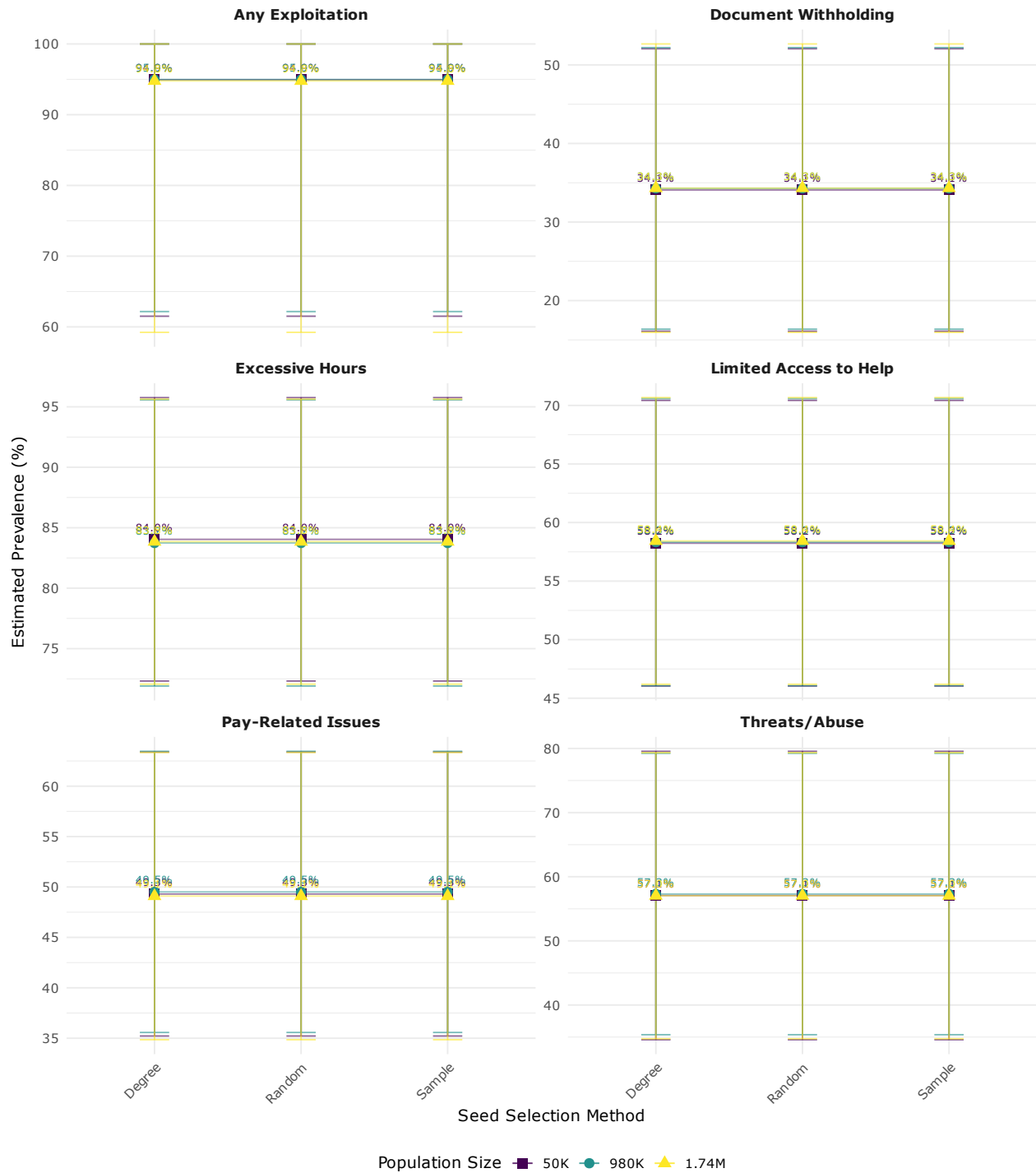


Figure 7: Model-Assisted Sensitivity by Population Size and Seed Selection: Point estimates with 95% credible intervals for each exploitation indicator across all parameter combinations. Each panel shows one indicator with estimates varying by population size (color) and seed selection method (shape).

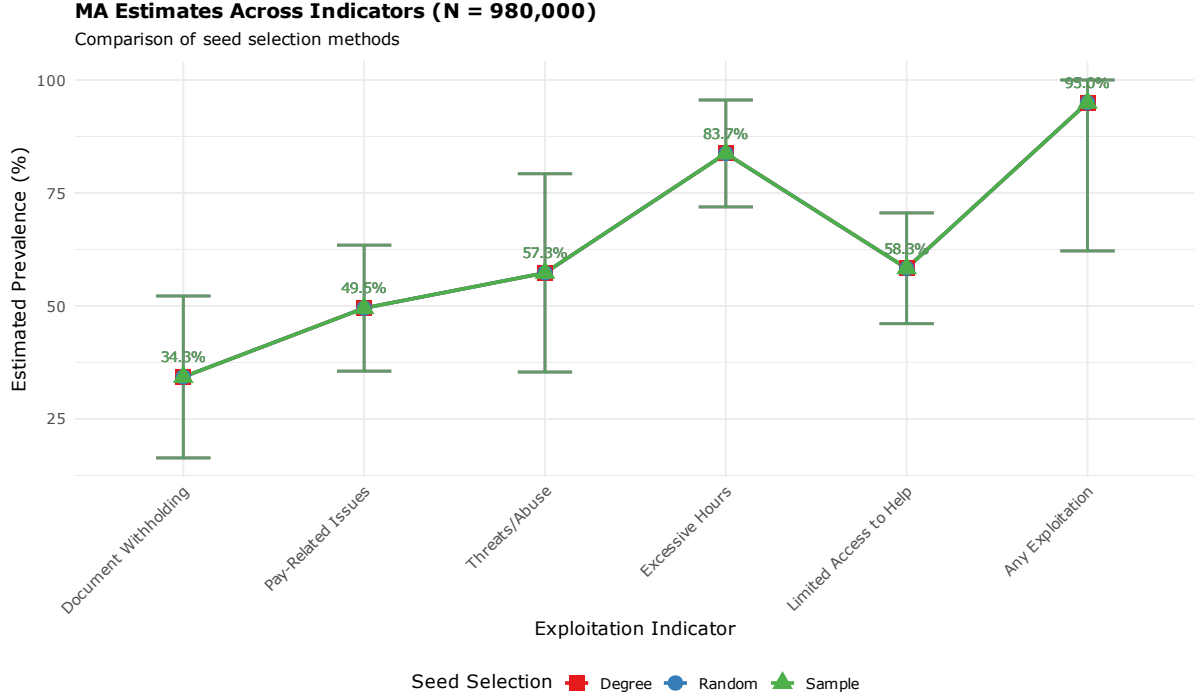


Figure 8: Model-Assisted Point Estimate Comparison: Direct comparison of point estimates across all indicators, fixing population size at 980K. Lines connect estimates using the same seed selection method, showing consistency across indicators.

NSUM Sensitivity Analysis

The NSUM estimates presented in the main text (Section 5.2.3) used neighborhood bootstrap resampling, Sequential Sampling weights, and the Modified Basic Scale-Up (MBSU) estimator with a population size of 980,000. To assess the robustness of these findings, we conducted comprehensive sensitivity analyses varying four key methodological choices: (1) bootstrap method, (2) weighting scheme, (3) population size assumption, and (4) NSUM estimator specification.

Sensitivity to Bootstrap Method

We compared four bootstrap resampling approaches: neighborhood bootstrap, tree bootstrap, chain bootstrap, and sequential sampling bootstrap. As shown in Table 8, all methods produce nearly identical point estimates, with variation only in confidence interval widths. This demonstrates that our findings are robust to the choice of bootstrap method, with the neighborhood bootstrap providing slightly more conservative (wider) confidence intervals than alternative approaches.

Table 8: Sensitivity Analysis: Bootstrap Method Comparison. All estimates use SS weights, N=980,000, and MBSU (Moderate) adjustment. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Bootstrap Method	Outcome	Point Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	Prevalence (%)
chain	Access to Help	19,885.25	9,065.943	46,394.68	2.03% (0.93% - 4.73%)
neighboot	Access to Help	19,885.25	6,539.872	47,818.24	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
ss	Access to Help	19,885.25	9,724.907	45,652.08	2.03% (0.99% - 4.66%)
tree	Access to Help	19,885.25	9,384.441	44,972.27	2.03% (0.96% - 4.59%)
chain	Document Withholding	10,614.74	4,208.011	27,779.56	1.08% (0.43% - 2.83%)
neighboot	Document Withholding	10,614.74	2,905.123	30,651.82	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
ss	Document Withholding	10,614.74	4,043.849	27,114.03	1.08% (0.41% - 2.77%)
tree	Document Withholding	10,614.74	4,442.185	26,596.79	1.08% (0.45% - 2.71%)
chain	Excessive Hours	29,248.47	20,279.843	52,819.48	2.98% (2.07% - 5.39%)
neighboot	Excessive Hours	29,248.47	18,064.258	53,994.30	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
ss	Excessive Hours	29,248.47	20,828.321	51,614.84	2.98% (2.13% - 5.27%)
tree	Excessive Hours	29,248.47	20,516.331	52,876.12	2.98% (2.09% - 5.40%)
chain	Pay Issues	28,182.36	19,510.454	49,813.16	2.88% (1.99% - 5.08%)
neighboot	Pay Issues	28,182.36	18,621.784	55,708.78	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
ss	Pay Issues	28,182.36	20,207.083	48,369.21	2.88% (2.06% - 4.94%)
tree	Pay Issues	28,182.36	20,147.528	49,462.95	2.88% (2.06% - 5.05%)
chain	Threats/Abuse	26,328.26	18,812.507	47,540.65	2.69% (1.92% - 4.85%)
neighboot	Threats/Abuse	26,328.26	18,179.435	57,424.35	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)
ss	Threats/Abuse	26,328.26	18,859.240	44,641.39	2.69% (1.92% - 4.56%)
tree	Threats/Abuse	26,328.26	18,678.408	46,053.23	2.69% (1.91% - 4.70%)

Note: All estimates use Sequential Sampling weights, population size of 980,000, and MBSU estimator with moderate adjustments ($\alpha=0.9$, $\beta=0.85$).

Table 9: Sensitivity Analysis: Weight Method Comparison. All estimates use neighborhood bootstrap, N=980,000, and MBSU (Moderate) adjustment. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Weight Method	Outcome	Point Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	Prevalence (%)
SS	Access to Help	19,885.25	6,539.872	47,818.24	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
VH	Access to Help	19,885.25	6,539.872	47,818.24	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
SS	Document Withholding	10,614.74	2,905.123	30,651.82	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
VH	Document Withholding	10,614.74	2,905.123	30,651.82	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
SS	Excessive Hours	29,248.47	18,064.258	53,994.30	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
VH	Excessive Hours	29,248.47	18,064.258	53,994.30	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
SS	Pay Issues	28,182.36	18,621.784	55,708.78	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
VH	Pay Issues	28,182.36	18,621.784	55,708.78	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
SS	Threats/Abuse	26,328.26	18,179.435	57,424.35	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)
VH	Threats/Abuse	26,328.26	18,179.435	57,424.35	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)

Note: VH = Volz-Heckathorn weights; SS = Sequential Sampling weights. Both methods produce identical estimates as expected for RDS data.

Sensitivity to Weight Method

We compared Volz-Heckathorn (VH) and Sequential Sampling (SS) weighting schemes (Table 9). Results were identical for both methods, as both approaches appropriately account for the RDS sampling design and degree-based inclusion probabilities. This validates our choice of SS weights for the main analysis.

Sensitivity to Population Size

We tested four population size scenarios: 50,000, 100,000, 980,000, and 1,740,000 (Table 10). As expected, absolute counts scaled linearly with population size assumptions, while prevalence rates remained constant. This validates our estimation approach and demonstrates

Table 10: Sensitivity Analysis: Population Size Comparison. All estimates use neighborhood bootstrap, SS weights, and MBSU (Moderate) adjustment. Source: Authors' Own Work.

Population Size	Outcome	Point Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	Prevalence (%)
50,000	Access to Help	1,014.5535	333.6670	2,439.706	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
100,000	Access to Help	2,029.1070	667.3339	4,879.412	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
980,000	Access to Help	19,885.2490	6,539.8722	47,818.238	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
1,740,000	Access to Help	35,306.4626	11,611.6099	84,901.769	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
50,000	Document Withholding	541.5682	148.2205	1,563.868	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
100,000	Document Withholding	1,083.1364	296.4411	3,127.737	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
980,000	Document Withholding	10,614.7367	2,905.1225	30,651.818	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
1,740,000	Document Withholding	18,846.5733	5,158.0747	54,422.616	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
50,000	Excessive Hours	1,492.2687	921.6458	2,754.811	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
100,000	Excessive Hours	2,984.5374	1,843.2916	5,509.622	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
980,000	Excessive Hours	29,248.4665	18,064.2575	53,994.296	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
1,740,000	Excessive Hours	51,930.9508	32,073.2736	95,867.424	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
50,000	Pay Issues	1,437.8754	950.0910	2,842.285	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
100,000	Pay Issues	2,875.7508	1,900.1821	5,684.569	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
980,000	Pay Issues	28,182.3576	18,621.7844	55,708.778	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
1,740,000	Pay Issues	50,038.0635	33,063.1682	98,911.504	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
50,000	Threats/Abuse	1,343.2783	927.5222	2,929.814	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)
100,000	Threats/Abuse	2,686.5566	1,855.0444	5,859.628	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)
980,000	Threats/Abuse	26,328.2551	18,179.4355	57,424.355	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)
1,740,000	Threats/Abuse	46,746.0856	32,277.7732	101,957.527	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)

Note: Prevalence rates remain constant across population sizes, demonstrating validity of estimation approach. We use N=980,000 as our baseline estimate of UK domestic worker population.

Table 11: Sensitivity Analysis: NSUM Method and Adjustment Factor Comparison. All estimates use neighborhood bootstrap, SS weights, and N=980,000. Source: Authors' Own Work.

NSUM Method	Outcome	Point Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	Prevalence (%)
GNSUM Symmetric					
GNSUM Symmetric	Access to Help	15,212.216	5,003.002	36,206.06	1.53% (0.51% - 3.77%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Access to Help	27,164.671	8,933.933	65,323.13	2.77% (0.91% - 6.67%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Access to Help	19,885.249	6,539.872	47,818.24	2.03% (0.67% - 4.88%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Access to Help	15,212.216	5,003.002	36,206.06	1.53% (0.51% - 3.77%)
GNSUM Symmetric	Document Withholding	8,120.274	2,222.419	23,448.64	0.83% (0.23% - 2.39%)
MBSU Conservative ($\delta=0.8$, $\tau=0.7$)					
MBSU (Conservative)	Document Withholding	14,500.488	3,968.605	41,872.57	1.48% (0.40% - 4.27%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Document Withholding	10,614.737	2,905.123	30,651.82	1.08% (0.30% - 3.13%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Document Withholding	8,120.274	2,222.419	23,448.64	0.83% (0.23% - 2.39%)
GNSUM Symmetric	Excessive Hours	22,375.077	13,819.157	41,205.64	2.28% (1.41% - 4.21%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Excessive Hours	39,955.494	24,677.066	73,760.07	4.08% (2.52% - 7.53%)
MBSU Moderate ($\delta=0.9$, $\tau=0.85$)					
MBSU (Moderate)	Excessive Hours	29,248.467	18,064.258	53,994.30	2.98% (1.84% - 5.51%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Excessive Hours	22,375.077	13,819.157	41,205.64	2.28% (1.41% - 4.21%)
GNSUM Symmetric	Pay Issues	21,559.504	14,245.665	42,617.22	2.30% (1.45% - 4.35%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Pay Issues	38,499.114	25,338.688	76,102.17	3.93% (2.60% - 7.77%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Pay Issues	28,182.358	18,621.784	55,708.78	2.88% (1.90% - 5.68%)
MBSU No Adjustment ($\delta=1.0$, $\tau=1.0$)					
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Pay Issues	21,559.504	14,245.665	42,617.22	2.30% (1.45% - 4.35%)
GNSUM Symmetric	Threats/Abuse	20,141.115	13,907.268	43,929.63	2.06% (1.42% - 4.48%)
MBSU (Conservative)	Threats/Abuse	35,966.277	24,834.407	78,445.77	3.67% (2.53% - 8.06%)
MBSU (Moderate)	Threats/Abuse	26,328.255	18,179.435	57,424.35	2.69% (1.86% - 5.86%)
MBSU (No Adjustment)	Threats/Abuse	20,141.115	13,907.268	43,929.63	2.06% (1.42% - 4.48%)

Note: MBSU = Modified Basic Scale-Up; GNSUM = Generalized Network Scale-Up Method; δ = degree ratio (network size differences); τ = visibility/true positive rate (transmission and reporting accuracy). Adjustment factors control for network degree differences and visibility/reporting biases in network-based estimation.

that the choice of population size affects the scale but not the proportional prevalence estimates.

Sensitivity to NSUM Method and Adjustment Factors

The choice of NSUM estimator and adjustment factors had substantial impact on estimates (Table 11). We compared MBSU with three adjustment factor sets (no adjustment, moderate, conservative) and GNSUM Symmetric estimation. GNSUM estimates matched MBSU (No Adjustment) exactly for all indicators, while conservative MBSU adjustments ($\delta = 0.8$, $\tau = 0.7$) produced estimates approximately 1.8 times higher than unadjusted estimates. Moderate adjustments ($\delta=0.9$, $\tau=0.85$) provided intermediate values approximately 1.3 times higher than baseline, representing our preferred specification that acknowledges likely visibility and reporting barriers while avoiding extreme assumptions.

Summary of Sensitivity Analyses

Across all 128 parameter combinations tested (4 bootstrap methods $\times$ 4 population sizes $\times$ 2 weight methods $\times$ 4 NSUM methods), prevalence estimates ranged from 0.83% to 4.08% for the five exploitation indicators. The most important source of variation was the choice of adjustment factors, with conservative adjustments producing estimates up to twice as high as unadjusted estimates. Bootstrap method, weight scheme, and population size assumptions had minimal impact on prevalence rates, demonstrating the robustness of our findings to these methodological choices.

For the main text analysis, we selected neighborhood bootstrap (providing conservative confidence intervals), SS weights (standard for RDS data), $N=980,000$ (based on EU labor force data), and MBSU with moderate adjustments (acknowledging likely barriers while avoiding extreme assumptions). This specification provides credible estimates while acknowledging uncertainty and avoiding both overly optimistic and overly pessimistic scenarios.

Appendix C: Bootstrap Estimation for Network Scale-Up Using RDS Data

Introduction

When estimating the size or characteristics of a hidden population using the Network Scale-Up Method (NSUM), researchers typically assume a probability sample from the frame population. However, in many applied settings—including hard-to-reach populations—data are collected via Respondent-Driven Sampling (RDS). RDS introduces specific structural dependencies and inclusion probabilities that violate the assumptions of simple random sampling.

This presents a challenge: how can we correctly estimate uncertainty for NSUM estimates derived from an RDS sample? As shown in Feehan and Salganik (2016) and Salganik (2006), the NSUM estimator depends crucially on inclusion weights π_i , which must reflect the sampling design. When data are RDS-based, these weights are typically derived from known degree-based estimators such as RDS-I, or RDS-II or Gile’s Successive Sampling (SS) weights.

To address this challenge, we propose a three-step bootstrap procedure for NSUM estimation using RDS data. This approach is flexible, modular, and applicable across several classes of NSUM estimators. It separates the issues of: 1. How to resample an RDS chain (Step 1), 2. How to recalculate sample-specific weights (Step 2), and 3. How to apply a chosen NSUM estimator (Step 3).

Step 1: Resampling the RDS Sample

We begin by resampling from the observed RDS sample in a way that mimics the original recruitment structure. Let the original sample be:

$$\mathcal{S} = \{i_1, i_2, \dots, i_n\}$$

with recruitment chains and wave indicators. Let d_i denote self-reported degree for respondent i , and let the recruitment tree structure be encoded via seed/recruiter IDs.

Options for RDS Resampling

- Tree Bootstrap: Sample entire recruitment trees (originating from seeds) with replacement. This respects the hierarchical recruitment structure and allows design effect estimation (Salganik, 2006).
- Successive Sampling Bootstrap (SSB): Sample with replacement according to inclusion probabilities derived from the SS model (Gile, 2011).
- Neighborhood Bootstrap: Use ego-network topology to preserve recruitment ties and neighborhood structure (Yauck et al., 2022).

- Chain Bootstrap: Each bootstrap replicate samples chains or subchains with replacement, preserving recruiter–recruitee links. This is implemented in `surveybootstrap::rds.boot.draw.chain()` and used in studies like Weir et al. (2012).

Let $\mathcal{S}^{(b)}$ denote the sample drawn in bootstrap replicate b .

Step 2: Recalculating Weights

NSUM estimators require inclusion weights π_i or their inverses $w_i = 1/\pi_i$. Because bootstrap samples differ in composition and recruitment pattern, these weights must be recomputed for each replicate.

General Structure

For each replicate b , construct: - $\mathcal{S}^{(b)}$: resampled respondent IDs - $d_i^{(b)}$: degree reports in replicate - $\pi_i^{(b)}$: estimated inclusion probabilities

Weighting Options

- RDS-II Weights (Volz & Heckathorn, 2008):

$$w_i^{(b)} \propto \frac{1}{d_i^{(b)}}$$

- SS Weights (Gile, 2011): Incorporate sampling fraction and frame size N_F . Computed numerically via successive sampling approximation.

Let $\mathbf{X}_i$ denote covariates (e.g. traits, degree, indicator of hidden population membership), which are retained from the original data and passed to Step 3.

Step 3: NSUM Estimation on Resampled and Reweighted Data

Given a bootstrap sample $\mathcal{S}^{(b)}$, we estimate the size of the hidden population N_H using one of several NSUM estimators. All estimators rely on weighted sums of out-reports and degree.

(a) Generalized NSUM (GNSUM)

As described in Feehan and Salganik (2016), GNSUM estimates:

$$\hat{N}_H^{(b)} = \left(\frac{\sum_i \frac{y_{i,H}}{\pi_i^{(b)}}}{\sum_i \frac{d_i}{\pi_i^{(b)}}} \right) \cdot N_F$$

Where:

- $y_{i,H}$: number of known alters in the hidden population,
- d_i : degree (known network size, e.g. from Q13),
- N_F : size of the frame population (e.g. domestic workers in UK).

(b) GNSUM with Symmetric Visibility (for Hidden Members in RDS)

In our context, some RDS respondents are ex post identified as members of the hidden population. Under the symmetric visibility assumption, if $i \in H$, we assume the probability that i knows j is the same as j knows i . This allows in-reports to be incorporated.

Let:

- $I_H(i) = 1$ if $i \in H$, 0 otherwise
- y_i^{in} : number of other hidden members who report knowing i

Then the estimator becomes:

$$\hat{N}_H^{(b)} = \left(\frac{\sum_i \frac{y_{i,H} + I_H(i) \cdot y_i^{\text{in}}}{\pi_i^{(b)}}}{\sum_i \frac{d_i}{\pi_i^{(b)}}} \right) \cdot N_F$$

(c) Modified Basic Scale-Up (MBSU)

This estimator adjusts for key reporting biases via three correction factors:

$$\hat{N}_H^{(b)} = \left(\frac{\sum_i \frac{y_{i,H}}{\pi_i^{(b)}}}{\sum_i \frac{d_i}{\pi_i^{(b)}}} \right) \cdot N_F \cdot \frac{1}{\delta \cdot \tau \cdot \rho}$$

Where:

- $\delta ()$: Degree ratio ($\bar{d}_{H,F}/\bar{d}_{F,F}$) — ratio of average network degree of hidden population to frame population,

- $\tau ()$: Visibility / true positive rate ($\bar{v}_{H,F}/\bar{d}_{H,F}$) — proportion of network edges correctly reported; measures transmission and reporting accuracy; captures visibility of hidden population to frame population,
- $\rho ()$: Popularity bias (relative visibility of hidden population members).

These values can be:

- Estimated using known subpopulations (e.g., alter groups with known size),
- Set by expert elicitation,
- Scanned in sensitivity analysis.

(d) Model-Based NSUM

Bayesian implementations (e.g. Maltiel et al. (2015)) model:

- Degree distributions,
- Reporting error,
- Group visibility,
- Hidden population size.

They yield a posterior distribution over N_H , and uncertainty is embedded within the model.

This step applies an NSUM estimator to the bootstrap sample $\mathcal{S}^{(b)}$ using the recalculated weights $w_i^{(b)}$ and responses $y_{i,H}$, where $y_{i,H}$ is the number of known contacts respondent i has in hidden population H .

Let N_F denote the frame population size (assumed known), and let d_i be the degree of respondent i .

Step 4: Aggregating Bootstrap Estimates

After B replicates:

$$\hat{N}_H^{(1)}, \dots, \hat{N}_H^{(B)}$$

We compute:

- Point estimate: $\bar{N}_H = \frac{1}{B} \sum_b \hat{N}_H^{(b)}$
- Standard error: sample SD
- 95% CI: empirical percentiles (e.g., 2.5%, 97.5%)